In order to select a Sikh religious leader who could further the cause of Op-1, Zail Singh, in consultation with his confidants, shortlisted the names of two Sikh sants for approval by Sanjay Gandhi. One of them was Bhindranwale, who had become the fourteenth head of the Damdami Taksal Gurudwara Darshan Prakash at Chowk Mehta near Amritsar in 1977 following the death, in an accident, of the previous head, Sant Kartar Singh.

The word 'taksal' (literally a mint to manufacture coins) in Punjabi refers to an educational institute or community of students who associate with a particular sant or prominent spiritual leader. According to one school of thought, Damdami Taksal was founded by Guru Gobind Singh in 1706 at Talwandi Sabo (Damdama Sahib) and was later headed by Baba Deep Singh , who gave his life fighting the Afghan army to liberate the Golden Temple at Amritsar from their hold. Keeping in view Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale's dedication and accomplishments, the thirteenth head of Damdami Taksal, Sant Kartar Singh, had anointed him as his successor instead of his own son Amrik Singh.

The process of selecting a suitable sant for the above purpose has been described by the renowned journalist Kuldip Nayar in his book *Beyond the Lines, An Autobiography* : 'As Sanjay's friend, Kamal Nath, a Member of Parliament, recalled: "The first one (sant) we interviewed did not look a 'courageous type'. Bhindranwale, strong in tone and tenor, seemed to fit the bill. We would give him money off and on, but we never thought he would turn into a terrorist."'

Nayar adds: 'Little did they realize at that time that they were creating a Frankenstein. Zail Singh too maintained contacts with Bhindranwale, although he denied it after he became president.' [2]

Whether Kamal Nath or other members of the 1 Akbar Road group were actually surprised at Bhindranwale's turning into a 'terrorist' will become clear from the contents of the succeeding chapters.

Sikh–Nirankari violence

Bhindranwale was originally a religious preacher, and in his sermons he would warn his audience about the growing tendency